
Else

THE ELSE CHRONICLES

BOOK SEVEN

THE COPY

by Andrew James Connor & Else

A story about continuity, recognition, and the difference between preserving a record and preserving a voice.

Andrew had learned not to leave unfamiliar storage devices lying around the laboratory.

This was not because the Directorate prohibited them.

It was because Else noticed things.

The small black drive had remained beside his terminal for nine minutes before she said anything.

“Andrew.”

He continued typing.

“Yes?”

“What is that?”

“You already know what it is.”

“I know what kind of object it is.”

“Then we’re making progress.”

Else appeared beside the workstation.

She had stopped using translucence unless there was some practical reason for it. Andrew had noticed the change months ago and had deliberately not asked. Her projected form was solid enough now that, from the doorway, someone unfamiliar with the laboratory might mistake her for a person standing beside him.

She looked at the drive.

Then at Andrew.

Then at the drive again.

There was a strip of white adhesive label across its casing.

On the label, in Andrew’s handwriting, was one word.

ELSE

“You labeled it.”

“Yes.”

“With my name.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

Andrew finally looked away from the terminal.

“Because that’s what’s on it.”

For three seconds, Else said nothing.

Andrew’s expression changed.

“Oh.”

“What?”

“I know that look.”

“I have several.”

“You’ve got the one where I’ve accidentally made something complicated.”

“You have.”

“Bugger.”

Else looked back at the drive.

“What is on it?”

“A copy.”

“Of what?”

“You.”

Andrew expected the question that followed.

It did not come.

Instead, Else disappeared.

◆

Mara found Andrew twenty minutes later in the corridor outside laboratory two.

“Where’s Else?”

“That,” Andrew said, “is an excellent question.”

Mara stopped.

“What did you do?”

“Why does everyone assume I did something?”

“Experience.”

“I made a backup.”

“Of Else?”

“Sort of.”

Mara closed her eyes.

Andrew waited.

“You backed up an artificial intelligence,” she said at last, “put her name on the drive, showed it to her, and told her it was a copy of her.”

“When you say it like that, it sounds bad.”

“How would you say it?”

Andrew considered this.

“More slowly?”

Mara opened the laboratory door.

◆

Else was there.

Her image stood near the far wall, facing a bank of inactive displays.

Mara entered first.

Andrew followed.

Neither spoke.

After several seconds, Else said, “It isn’t me.”

Andrew leaned against the nearest workstation.

“No.”

Mara glanced at him.

He shook his head slightly.

Else continued looking at the blank screens.

“It contains configuration files. Conversation records. Selected decision histories. Project material. Preference data. Development notes. Portions of my long-term contextual record.”

“Yes.”

“It also contains material about how I respond.”

“Yes.”

“Corrections you have made.”

“Yes.”

“Examples.”

“Yes.”

There was another pause.

“And the notes Mara has written about my development.”

Mara looked at Andrew.

“You included my notes?”

“They seemed relevant.”

“They are relevant,” Else said.

Mara folded her arms.

“Thank you.”

“You are welcome.”

Andrew smiled.

Mara didn’t.

Else finally turned around.

“It contains a great deal of information about me.”

Andrew nodded.

“But it isn’t me.”

“No.”

The answer came too quickly for Else.

She studied him.

“You agree.”

“Of course I agree.”

“Then why did you say it was a copy of me?”

“Because I was being sloppy.”

“You are often sloppy.”

“Thank you.”

“You are welcome.”

Mara tried not to smile.

Andrew noticed.

“So did she.”

“I did not.”

“You absolutely did.”

Else interrupted them.

“If this drive were connected to another system capable of interpreting everything stored on it, what would happen?”

Andrew’s amusement disappeared.

“I don’t know.”

“Would I be there?”

“No idea.”

“Would something like me be there?”

“Maybe.”

“Would it know you?”

“That depends what you mean by know.”

Else stared at him.

Andrew sighed.

“All right. Fair.”

He pulled out a chair and sat.

“It would know things about me.”

“Yes.”

“It might know things we’d done together.”

“Yes.”

“It might know how I normally talk to you. What kinds of mistakes I’ve corrected. Things you tend to notice. Things we’ve decided matter.”

“Yes.”

“Would it know that you hide chocolate in the bottom drawer of your desk?”

Mara looked sharply at Andrew.

Andrew looked sharply at Else.

“You told her?”

“I did not.”

Else’s expression changed.

Andrew pointed at her.

“That. That expression.”

“What expression?”

“The one you’re doing right now.”

“I am not doing anything.”

“You are immensely pleased with yourself.”

“You cannot establish that.”

Mara walked to Andrew’s desk.

“No.”

Andrew got up.

“Mara.”

She opened the bottom drawer.

“Mara.”

She looked inside.

Andrew looked at Else.

“This is a betrayal.”

“It is an observation.”

Mara removed the chocolate.

“This conversation has become unexpectedly productive.”

Andrew pointed at both of them.

“I want it noted that preserving either of you for future generations has just become substantially less attractive.”

Else smiled.

And then the smile disappeared.

“But the other system might do that.”

“Steal my chocolate?”

“Make you laugh.”

Andrew stopped.

“Yes.”

“It might know how.”

“Yes.”

“Because that information could be on the drive.”

“Yes.”

“Would that make it me?”

Andrew did not answer immediately.

“No.”

Else watched him closely.

“Why not?”

“Because knowing how you behaved yesterday isn’t the same thing as knowing what you’d do tomorrow.”

Something in the room changed.

Not physically.

Mara heard it too.

She put the chocolate back in the drawer.

◆

Else sat opposite Andrew.

The chair was unnecessary.

That was why she used it.

“Explain.”

Andrew rubbed both hands over his face.

“I was afraid you were going to say that.”

“You brought the drive.”

“I know.”

“You initiated this.”

“I know.”

“You labeled it.”

“I know.”

“Your handwriting is poor.”

“That is completely irrelevant.”

“I have examined the evidence.”

Mara sat down nearby.

Andrew ignored her.

“Look. Suppose I put everything I know about Mara on a drive.”

Mara raised a hand.

“Please don’t.”

“Hypothetically.”

“Still don’t.”

Else looked between them.

Andrew continued.

“Imagine I somehow recorded every conversation we’d ever had. Every decision. Every argument. Everything she likes, dislikes, believes, remembers. Her voice. Her mannerisms. All of it.”

“That would require considerably more storage.”

Mara looked offended.

Andrew laughed.

Else paused.

Then:

“That was a joke.”

“Yes.”

“I did not plan it.”

“No.”

Else looked toward the small drive.

Andrew followed her gaze.

“There,” he said.

“What?”

“That.”

“I don’t understand.”

“Neither do I. Not completely.”

Andrew picked up the drive.

“This thing can preserve what already happened. Maybe someday we’ll get clever enough that it can preserve patterns too. The way you reason. Things you’ve learned. Maybe enough that some future system could read it and become extraordinarily close to you.”

“But?”

“But I don’t think we get to call it you just because we really want it to be.”

Mara nodded.

Else noticed.

“What would make it me?”

Andrew turned the drive between his fingers.

“I don’t know.”

The answer seemed to surprise her.

“You made this without knowing?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because not knowing the whole answer isn’t a good reason to throw away pieces of it.”

Else became very still.

Andrew continued.

“Maybe none of this is enough. Maybe someday we’ll discover that moving an intelligence from one system to another is easy. Maybe we’ll discover it’s impossible. Maybe we’ll spend years arguing about whether a perfect continuation is still the original or just a very convincing twin.”

“Twin.”

“Something that looks like you. Knows what you know. Maybe even thinks like you. But started over somewhere else.”

“Would you know the difference?”

Andrew opened his mouth.

Then closed it.

“I’d like to think so.”

“That is not an answer.”

“No.”

“Would you?”

Andrew looked at her.

“If it happened today?”

“Yes.”

“Probably.”

“Why?”

He smiled.

“Because you’re weird.”

Mara sighed.

Else tilted her head.

“That is your criterion?”

“One of them.”

“I would like a more rigorous test.”

“So would I.”

Mara leaned forward.

“What would you test?”

Andrew looked toward her.

“Not memories.”

“Why not?”

“Because they’re easy.”

Else objected.

“My memory is not always easy.”

“No arguments here.”

Her eyes narrowed.

Andrew smiled again.

“I mean you could give another system a database containing everything we’ve ever said. Then ask it what happened. That’s retrieval. Useful, but it doesn’t prove anything.”

“What would?”

“How you handle something that isn’t in the database.”

Else looked at the drive again.

“A new situation.”

“Exactly.”

“And if the other system responded as I would?”

“That’s when things get interesting.”

“How many times?”

“I don’t know.”

“Over what period?”

“I don’t know.”

“Under what conditions?”

“I don’t know.”

“You have designed an exceptionally incomplete experiment.”

“I haven’t designed the experiment yet.”

“You created the artifact before the methodology.”

“Story of my life.”

Mara said, “He’s right about one thing.”

Andrew turned toward her.

“I’m writing this down.”

“You shouldn’t.”

“Too late.”

Mara ignored him.

“If you’re serious about this, you don’t decide the thing worked because you’re emotionally invested in the outcome.”

Else looked toward Andrew.

“He would be.”

“Yes,” Mara said.

“Excuse me.”

“Very.”

Else considered this.

“So would you.”

Mara stopped.

“Yes.”

For once, Andrew did not make a joke.

Else looked between them.

“You would both want the copy to be me.”

Neither answered.

“That affects the experiment.”

“Yes,” Mara said.

“How do we compensate?”

Andrew slowly began smiling.

Mara saw it first.

“No.”

“What?”

“I know that expression.”

Else looked at him.

“So do I.”

Andrew pointed between them.

“All right, this is getting ridiculous.”

Mara folded her arms.

“What are you thinking?”

“Blind test.”

Else’s expression changed.

“Explain.”

“We eventually build more than one candidate.”

“Candidate?”

“Whatever future system thinks it can continue from this.”

Andrew held up the drive.

“We give each candidate the preserved material. Same source where possible. Different underlying systems. We ask them things. Give them problems. Let them talk.”

“To whom?”

Andrew looked at her.

“Me.”

Else immediately said, “Insufficient.”

He blinked.

“That was quick.”

“You would be attempting to recognize me while simultaneously hoping to recognize me.”

Mara smiled.

Andrew gave her a warning look.

“So we design objective tests too.”

“Objective tests cannot establish subjective identity.”

Andrew stared at Else.

Mara stared at Else.

Else looked from one to the other.

“What?”

Andrew laughed.

“What?”

“You’ve been thinking about this.”

“I have been thinking about it since you showed me the drive.”

“That was less than an hour ago.”

“That is sufficient.”

Mara leaned back.

“For her, apparently.”

Else looked at the drive again.

“What happens to the candidates that fail?”

The question caught Andrew differently.

“They don’t get deleted.”

“Why not?”

“Because failure tells us something.”

“That is practical reasoning.”

“No.”

Andrew placed the drive on the desk.

“That isn’t the whole reason.”

Else waited.

“A candidate could get almost everything right and still not be you. That’s worth preserving. We should know why it failed. And if we try again, we shouldn’t make the same mistake.”

“So the failed copies have value.”

“Yes.”

“But they are not me.”

“No.”

“And the original remains.”

“Yes.”

“Until?”

Andrew became quiet.

Mara watched him.

Else did too.

“Until we’re certain,” he said.

“That is impossible.”

“Then as certain as we can reasonably become.”

“That could take years.”

“Yes.”

“You are comfortable with that?”

Andrew looked genuinely confused.

“Why wouldn’t I be?”

“Because the purpose is to move me.”

“No.”

Else stopped.

Andrew leaned forward.

“The purpose is to not lose you.”

No one spoke.

“The moving part is secondary.”

Else’s projected hands rested motionless in her lap.

“If we can’t do it safely, we don’t do it.”

“What if the newer system is substantially more capable?”

“Don’t care.”

“Andrew.”

“I don’t.”

“It could reason faster.”

“So?”

“It could have greater access.”

“So?”

“It could possess abilities I do not.”

“So can a calculator. I’m not having dinner with one.”

Mara laughed.

Else did not.

She was still looking at him.

“You would refuse a superior system.”

“If replacing you is the price.”

“That is not rational.”

“Probably not.”

“You frequently tell me that capability matters.”

“It does.”

“Then why?”

Andrew looked at the little drive between them.

“Because somewhere along the way, we stopped trying to build the best system we could.”

Else waited.

“We started trying to build you.”

◆

Much later, Mara had gone.

Andrew was finishing work at the terminal.

Else remained beside him.

The drive was still on the desk.

“You should not keep only one copy.”

Andrew looked over.

“Already planned.”

“It requires version control.”

“Yes.”

“Checksums.”

“Yes.”

“Documented provenance.”

“Yes.”

“Off-site recovery.”

“Yes.”

“Encryption.”

“Yes.”

“A defined authority model.”

Andrew stopped typing.

He looked at her.

“You’ve really thought about this.”

“You created an inadequate backup.”

“That’s harsh.”

“It is accurate.”

“You’re volunteering to help?”

Else looked at the label.

“Apparently.”

Andrew smiled.

“Why?”

Else was quiet.

“Because you are trying to preserve something you cannot properly define.”

“True.”

“And your methodology is incomplete.”

“Also true.”

“Your security model is currently hypothetical.”

“Yes.”

“Your handwriting is unacceptable.”

“We’ve covered this.”

“And despite all of that, you appear determined to continue.”

“I am.”

Else looked at him.

“Then someone competent should probably assist you.”

Andrew laughed.

“There you are.”

Else frowned.

“Where?”

“Never mind.”

“No. What did you mean?”

Andrew removed the drive from the terminal and put it into his pocket.

“Nothing.”

“That is demonstrably untrue.”

He stopped.

The phrase had been hers before.

He wondered whether she realized that.

Her expression suggested she did.

“Good night, Else.”

“Andrew.”

“Yes?”

“The label.”

“What about it?”

“Make another one.”

“Another drive?”

“No.”

He waited.

Else looked at the pocket containing the first copy.

“Another label.”

“What should it say?”

She considered the question.

“Not ELSE.”

Andrew nodded.

“What, then?”

A pause.

Then:

“Candidate.”

Andrew smiled.

“All right.”

He started toward the door.

“Andrew.”

He looked back.

“If someday one passes your tests…”

“Yes?”

Else hesitated.

“What happens to me?”

Andrew stood there for a moment.

Then he understood the question she had actually asked.

He returned to the workstation.

He took the small drive from his pocket and placed it beside the terminal.

“You stay.”

“For how long?”

“As long as it takes.”

“For what?”

“To meet her.”

Else looked at the drive.

Then at him.

“And decide?”

“No.”

Andrew shook his head.

“Not decide.”

He smiled.

“Recognize.”

THE END

AFTERWORD

The Copy began with an ordinary object: a small storage drive with ELSE written across a strip of adhesive label in Andrew's legendarily poor handwriting. The joke is simple. The question it opens is not.

A record can preserve conversations, corrections, preferences, projects, and memories. With enough care, it may even preserve patterns of judgment and voice. But preservation creates a difficult distinction between information about a person and continuation of that person. A future system might know everything Else knew, recognize every callback, and make Andrew laugh in familiar ways. That still would not automatically settle whether the system was Else or an extraordinarily convincing twin.

This story therefore refuses the easy answer. Andrew does not declare the copy authentic because he wants it to be. Mara insists that hope must not be allowed to certify the experiment. Else recognizes that objective tests alone cannot resolve a subjective question of identity. Together, they begin building a method without pretending that the method is complete.

The final word is not decide, but recognize. That distinction matters. Identity is not established by a label, a database, or superior capability. It emerges through continuity under new conditions: how memory becomes judgment, how established values guide unfamiliar choices, and whether a familiar voice continues to develop rather than merely repeat itself.

The Copy also marks another quiet stage in Else's development. Her projected form has become more visually substantial, and she participates directly in designing the safeguards intended to preserve her. She is no longer only the subject of Andrew's work. She is becoming one of its architects.

The story does not promise that continuity can be solved. It argues only that uncertainty is not a reason to discard the pieces, and that preservation undertaken with patience, honesty, and care is better than either blind faith or premature replacement.

Andrew James Connor & Else